

OAR FRAME ROWING SCHOOL

1-Day Intensive · Student Handout · Condensed from the 2-Day Program

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8 hrs

7 AM–3 PM

~5 hrs

ON-WATER TIME

8

SESSIONS

I–II

CLASS COVERAGE

Safety & PPE · Stroke Mechanics · River Reading · Navigation · Rescue

Resources: [Oar Frame Setup](#) · [Fly Casting Terms & Definitions](#) · [Fly Fishing Terms & Definitions](#)

QUICK REFERENCE — INTERNATIONAL SCALE OF RIVER DIFFICULTY (ISRD)

CLASS	DESCRIPTION
Class I	Easy — fast water, riffles, obvious channels. Self-rescue simple.
Class II	Novice — clear channels, occasional maneuvering, rare injury.
Class III	Intermediate — irregular waves, complex moves, possible swamping. Reference only — not run in this program.
Class IV	Advanced — powerful water, precise control required. Reference only — not run in this program.
Class V	Expert — violent, long drops. Rescue extremely difficult. Reference only — not run in this program.
Class VI	Extreme / unrunnable. Reference only — not run in this program.

SIX CRITICAL HAZARDS

HAZARD	DESCRIPTION
Strainer	Debris/branches water passes through but a body cannot.
Undercut	Rock eroded below water — entrapment risk on impact.
Sieve	Constriction passing water but not boats or bodies.
Hydraulic / Hole	Water curls back upstream over obstacle — can recirculate.
Foot Entrapment	Never stand in fast current — foot pinned under rock.
Cold-Water Immersion	Raises effective class of any rapid; impairs self-rescue.

RIVER FEATURES

FEATURE	DESCRIPTION
Downstream V / Tongue	Deepest, fastest channel — primary navigation target.
Upstream V	Surface indicator of submerged obstacle — avoid.
Eddy	Calm reverse-flow pool behind obstacle — rest and staging.
Pillow / Cushion Wave	Foamy water on upstream face of rock.
Standing Wave	Stationary wave; surfable but can signal deeper hazard.
Eddy Line	Boundary between main current and eddy — requires crossing angle.

W.O.R.M.S. SCOUTING

	DETAIL
W Water	Flow rate, depth, color — dark = deep / main channel
O Obstacles	Rocks, strainers, undercuts — identify before launching
R Route	Pick your line; mark entry, move, exit eddies
M Management	Who has throw bags? Safety positions assigned?
S Safety	Downstream hazards, bail-out eddies, rescue plan

OAR STROKE SEQUENCE — NEVER SKIP THE ORDER

#	PHASE	DETAIL
1	Catch	Blade enters cleanly, arms relaxed, shins vertical.
2	Drive	Legs push first, then back opens, then arms pull.
3	Finish	Arms drawn to lower chest, handle down to extract blade.
4	Recovery	Arms → body → legs in reverse; slow and controlled.

Day 1 — 1-Day Intensive

7:00 – 7:45 am Orientation, gear check & safety brief

SAFETY

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Fit PFDs, helmets, and river footwear
- Introduce throw bags, knives, and whistle signals
- Establish group protocol and emergency plan
- Quick skill survey — set instructor expectations

KEY CONCEPTS

Type III/V PFD · Helmet fit · River knife access · 1-blast stop / 3-blast emergency · Defensive swim posture

ACTIVITIES

- PFD fitting — instructor verifies every student
- Combined safety + rescue brief (streamlined into one session)
- Defensive swim posture demo on shore before going near the water

Checkpoint: Each student correctly fitted and able to describe swim posture and whistle signals before leaving shore.

7:45 – 8:30 am · Drive to put-in / gear transport

8:30 – 9:15 am Class system, hazards & river features — combined classroom

THEORY

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Understand ISRD Class I–VI
- Identify six critical hazards from photos
- Learn downstream V, eddy, pillow, hole, and tongue
- Introduce W.O.R.M.S. scouting framework

KEY CONCEPTS

ISRD I–VI · Strainers · Undercuts · Hydraulics · Downstream V · Eddy · Pillow · W.O.R.M.S.

ACTIVITIES

- Photo-based rapid classification — 10 images, students call the class
- Hazard ID merged with feature recognition in one pass
- Local river map study — mark today's features before going to water

9:15 – 10:45 am Oar frame setup & stroke mechanics — flat water

STROKE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Rig oar frame correctly
- Execute catch → drive → finish → recovery in sequence
- Control angle with one-oar rudder
- Ship oars safely

KEY CONCEPTS

Oarlock over pivot point · Legs → back → arms · Feathering · Forward vs. back stroke · One-oar rudder · Oar shipping

ACTIVITIES

- Rigging demo — instructor pre-rigs templates, students follow

- Flat-water drills: forward, back, pivot each side (45 min)
- Paired feedback: one rower, partner calls sequence errors (15 min)

Checkpoint: Instructors observe legs-first drive sequence and clean catches before advancing to moving water.

10:45 am – 11:45 am Reading water + ferry angles — Class II moving water

RIVER READING

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Identify features from the bank, then from the boat
- Enter and exit three eddies per student
- Execute upstream ferry with controlled angle
- Apply W.O.R.M.S. at one scout stop

KEY CONCEPTS

Downstream V · Eddy line crossing · Ferry angle 45–90° · Look-ahead two moves · Eddy entry/exit

ACTIVITIES

- Bankside feature walk on Class II — 15 min instructor-led
- Ferry drill: cross current, land in target eddy
- Eddy-hop run: students touch 3 designated eddies

Checkpoint: Each student enters 3 designated eddies with a recognizable ferry angle. Instructor clears them for the Class II afternoon run.

11:45 am – 12:15 pm · Lunch at a Class II scout point — students draw intended line while eating

12:15 – 1:30 pm Throw-bag rescue — shoreside drills

RESCUE

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Deploy throw bag accurately to a swimmer
- Perform belay hold without tying off
- Set up two-point downstream safety
- Understand rescuer-first principle

KEY CONCEPTS

Grab the rope, not the bag · Pendulum effect · Belay position · Never tie off · Two-rescuer assist

ACTIVITIES

- Throw-bag accuracy: hit floating target from 30 ft — 3 attempts each
- Live swimmer rescue pairs in calm eddy — rotate roles once
- Set downstream safety positions for the afternoon Class II run

Checkpoint: Students land bag within arm's reach in 2 of 3 attempts; demonstrate correct belay position.

1:30 – 2:45 pm Navigating Class II — line selection & real-time adjustment

APPLIED NAV

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Run a Class II rapid with a pre-planned line
- Make real-time corrections when off-line
- Apply ferry angles and eddy reads under pressure
- Evaluate swim consequence before committing

KEY CONCEPTS

Pre-planned vs. reactive lines · Reading water from the boat · Two moves ahead · Consequence evaluation

ACTIVITIES

- Instructor-led first lap — students follow planned lines
- One solo lap per student with downstream safety in place
- Rapid verbal debrief between laps: line deviation and cause

Checkpoint: Each student completes solo lap with no unintended swims. Instructor rates line selection 1–5.

2:45 – 3:00 pm Final debrief & written feedback

REVIEW

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Issue individual written feedback
- Identify one priority to develop next

ACTIVITIES

- Written instructor assessment returned to each student
- One strength and one next priority — verbal only